vedas, include Ayurveda, the science of wellness, Dhanurveda, the science of weapons and the rules of warfare, Gandharva Veda, the science of the performing arts (including the classic text on music, dance and theatre, the *Natya Shastra*), and the Arthashastra, the treatise on statecraft that in many respects anticipated Machiavelli's *The Prince* by nearly two millennia. The Vedangas, the explanatory 'limbs' of the Vedas, deal with such matters as grammar, phonetics, etymology, the art of poetry, the science of rituals and (in the famous *Jyotisha Vedanga*) astronomy and astrology. All these again are the product of centuries of writing and reflection.

The Smritis are that which is remembered; they are composed by human beings without any specific divine inspiration and passed on to guide ordinary people in the conduct of their lives and the performance of their spiritual and worldly duties. The eighteen Smritis, written down largely over the five centuries between 300 BCE and 200 CE, are often referred to as the *Dharmashastras*, since they explicate how *dharma* must be observed, and these are seen as practices that must change with time and place. The Smritis describe the daily life of individuals, prescribing rituals and rules which vary according to each *varna* or social class and are collectively known as *varna-ashrama-dharma*. The Smritis also lay down the rules of governance, known as Raj Dharma, and adumbrate the earliest ideas of what may be considered a Hindu constitutional order, headed by a king. Among the most famous of the *smritis* is the Arthashastra, an ancient treatise on statecraft, economic policy and military strategy, composed between the 2nd century BCE and the 3rd century CE, and attributed by many to Chanakya or Kautilya, principal counsellor to the Emperor Chandragupta Maurya (though this is disputed). In its unsentimental explication of the duties and responsibilities of kings and states, and its ruthless advocacy of amoral policies including alliance-making, coercion and suborning of rivals, it anticipates by several centuries the prescriptions of Machiavelli.

Since the Smritis are purely man-made and mutable, Hinduism does not aver that laws laid down a millennium ago must be followed to the letter today. The foundational laws of Yajnavalkya and the Code of Manu, often cited as the source of 'Hindu law', are Smriti; no Hindu